

Lab 3 - OpenClaw Channel

Connect OpenClaw to messaging channels so users can chat with your agent. This lab covers Telegram (via BotFather) and WhatsApp (QR pairing).

Lab environment: Hostinger VPS (from Lab 1) or Docker Desktop (Windows 10/11, macOS 12+, Ubuntu 22.04+)

Prerequisite: Lab 2 completed - model provider configured and openclaw models status showing connected.

Estimated time: 30 minutes

Docker Desktop users: Prefix every openclaw command with `docker exec -it openclaw`.

Example: `docker exec -it openclaw openclaw channels add`

Part A - Telegram

Step A1 - Create a Bot via BotFather

1. Open Telegram and search for @BotFather
2. Send the command: `/newbot`
3. BotFather asks: What is the name of your bot?

Enter a display name, e.g. Alfred Agent

4. BotFather asks: What username for your bot?

Enter a unique username ending in bot, e.g. `alfred_agent_bot`

5. BotFather replies with your bot token:

```
Done! Use this token to access the HTTP API:
7123456789:AAGxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx
```

Copy this token - you need it in the next step.

Step A2 - Register the Bot Token with OpenClaw

Option 1 - Interactive wizard (recommended):

```
# VPS
openclaw channels add

# Docker Desktop
docker exec -it openclaw openclaw channels add
```

The wizard will ask you to select a channel - choose Telegram and paste your bot token when prompted.

Option 2 - Non-interactive (one command):

```
# VPS
openclaw channels add --channel telegram --token YOUR_BOT_TOKEN

# Docker Desktop
docker exec -it openclaw openclaw channels add --channel telegram --token YOUR_BOT_TOKEN
```

Expected output: `` ☐ Telegram channel added. Bot username: @alfred\_agent\_bot ``

Step A3 - Check Channel Status

```
# VPS
openclaw channels status

# Docker Desktop
docker exec -it openclaw openclaw channels status
```

Expected output: `` CHANNEL STATUS ACCOUNT telegram running @alfred\_agent\_bot ``

Step A4 - Approve Your Telegram User

The first time you message the bot, OpenClaw blocks access and asks for approval. This is a one-time pairing step.

1. Open Telegram, search for your bot (e.g. @alfred_agent_bot) and send /start
2. The bot replies with a pairing code, for example:

```
OpenClaw: access not configured.
Your Telegram user id: 7720963181
Pairing code: YTMKMQHW

Ask the bot owner to approve with:
openclaw pairing approve telegram YTMKMQHW
```

3. Copy the pairing code and run on your machine:

```
# VPS
openclaw pairing approve telegram YOUR_PAIRING_CODE

# Docker Desktop
docker exec -it openclaw openclaw pairing approve telegram YOUR_PAIRING_CODE
```

Expected output: `` ☐ Telegram user approved. ``

Step A5 - Test the Telegram Channel

Send a message to your bot in Telegram:

```
Hello
```

Expected: The agent replies with a greeting.

Part B - WhatsApp

Step B1 - Add the WhatsApp Channel

```
# VPS
openclaw channels add --channel whatsapp

# Docker Desktop
docker exec -it openclaw openclaw channels add --channel whatsapp
```

Step B2 - Link Your WhatsApp Account (QR Pairing)

```
# VPS
openclaw channels login --channel whatsapp

# Docker Desktop
docker exec -it openclaw openclaw channels login --channel whatsapp
```

OpenClaw prints a QR code in the terminal.

On your phone:

1. Open WhatsApp
2. Tap Settings → Linked Devices → Link a Device
3. Scan the QR code shown in your terminal

Expected terminal output after scanning: `` ☐ WhatsApp paired successfully. Phone: +65xxxxxxx ``

Step B3 - Check Channel Status

```
# VPS
openclaw channels status

# Docker Desktop
docker exec -it openclaw openclaw channels status
```

Expected output: `` CHANNEL STATUS ACCOUNT telegram running @alfred\_agent\_bot whatsapp running +65xxxxxxx ``

Step B4 - Test the WhatsApp Channel

Send a WhatsApp message to your linked number from another device.

Message: Hello

Expected: Agent replies in the same WhatsApp chat.

List All Configured Channels

```
# VPS
openclaw channels list

# Docker Desktop
docker exec -it openclaw openclaw channels list
```

Verification

Check	Expected
openclaw channels list	telegram and whatsapp listed

Check	Expected
openclaw channels status	Both channels showing running
Telegram message Hello	Agent replies in Telegram
WhatsApp message Hello	Agent replies in WhatsApp

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Fix
BotFather says "username already taken"	Choose a different username - must be unique globally
openclaw channel add not found	Use channels (plural) - openclaw channels add
Telegram bot says "access not configured"	Run openclaw pairing approve telegram YOUR_CODE to approve your user
Telegram bot does not reply after approval	Run openclaw channels status - confirm status is running
QR code expires before scanning	Re-run openclaw channels login --channel whatsapp for a new QR
WhatsApp says "Linked device limit reached"	Phone → Settings → Linked Devices → remove an old device
Docker: command not found	Add docker exec -it openclaw before every openclaw command

Reference

- Channels: <https://docs.openclaw.ai/channels>
- Telegram BotFather: <https://t.me/BotFather>